

LAUNCH PAD · A GUIDE'S LESSON PLAN BOOK

The Origin Year

Who am I?

A guide's book for Year One of the Launch Pad, written so a learner can read every page.

VIBRANT LIFE

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

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Part 4 - Closing the year

Opening note

This is the guide's book for the first year of the Launch Pad, the year called Origin. It holds the whole plan: the shape of the year, the seven sessions, the day-by-day flow, the things a guide might say, and the ways we keep everyone safe. It is written for the guide to teach from. It is also written so that any learner can pick it up and read the whole thing.

That last part is a rule, not an accident. Here is the rule, and it holds on every page:

Everything in this book is safe and honest for a learner to read. Nothing in it manages or manipulates anyone. Lines in "quotes" are things a guide might say aloud. Everything else is for the guide to understand and hold.

There is no hidden chapter. There is no page that says "here is how to get the reluctant kid to do the thing." A guide's notes here are transparent and kind. If a learner reads a note about themselves, they should feel respected, not handled. That is the whole point of the year, so it is the whole point of the book too.

One author's note on language: this book was written by Erin Stanley for the studio she runs. "The guide" is the person leading the studio. "You" sometimes means the guide and sometimes means the learner - the context always makes it clear which.

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

The year's question

Origin asks one question, all year: **Who am I?**

That is it. Not “who should you be,” not “who do we need you to become.” Just the honest, enormous question of who you already are and who you are turning into. Everything this year is a way of walking around that question and looking at it from a new side.

Origin is the first of three years. The three years each carry their own question:

- **Origin - Who am I?** (Know your story.)
- **The Forge - What is worth solving?** (Find your work.)
- **The Helm - What do I do when there is no easy answer?** (Make the hard call, and love the life around it.)

You start with your story because everything else stands on it. You cannot choose your work or make a hard call from principle if you have never taken the time to know who is doing the choosing.

The journey (the year's arc, plain)

The year is built like a story with a beginning, a middle, and an end.

You start by dreaming with no ceiling. You look at where you come from and the people who made you. You practice the muscle of choosing, and then the muscle of running your own days. Then, in the long middle of the year, you write your whole life down, all of it, unedited. After that you become the author of it, shaping it into something you can hold. And at the very end, you make a piece that says “this is me,” and you show it to your people.

Named plainly, the seven sessions are:

1. **The Map of Me** - dream 100 dreams and start naming what you want.
2. **The Lineage** - gather the stories of where you come from.
3. **The Power of Choice** - practice choosing on purpose.
4. **Running My Own Ship** - build a routine that fits you.
5. **The Full Draft** - write your whole life, unshaped.
6. **Chapter One** - become the author and shape it.
7. **This Is Me / The Unveiling** - make a self-portrait and show it.

The year rhymes from end to end: you dream it, you draft it, you shape it, you declare it.

What you make and carry

The Captain's Log. This year you begin one artifact you will carry through all three years: your Captain's Log. It is a record of your own life and your own thinking. You name it yourself. You write in it however you write. It belongs to you, completely. A guide never reads it to grade you or check up on you. The moment a private log becomes something someone else reads to judge you, it stops being yours, and this one stays yours. You will carry it out the door when you leave, and no copy is kept.

The Vineyard. On the very first day, alongside the Log, you name one more thing: a part of your week that is just yours to love. A thing you tend because you love it, and that no one will ever ask you what it was *for*. It is never harvested. It is never turned into an assignment. No one ever asks you to reflect on it or report on it. If a guide ever adds a "Vineyard reflection prompt," the whole thing is dead, so no one will.

The Vineyard is the quiet twin of the Captain's Log. The Log is the self examined. The Vineyard is the self delighted. You carry both from the first morning. And there is a floor under it: if your life is already full to breaking - a job, siblings to look after, someone to care for - and you have no room for a useless thing you love, that is honored too. A full-to-breaking basket is as real as an empty one. No one is shamed for having no room.

The promises (the six refusals)

Underneath everything, there is a floor of promises. Nothing in the Launch Pad is allowed to break these. In plain words:

1. **No grades or scores anyone but you can see.** Your progress is yours.
2. **No ranking and no leaderboards.** You are never stacked against the person next to you, and no one can see your progress bar but you.
3. **No one deposits the answers into you.** You make meaning here; the guide holds questions and walks with you, and does not hand you a finished you.
4. **No imposed deadlines.** You set your own pace. “I didn’t get to it” is honored, not punished.
5. **Your worth is not your output.** A quest you abandoned and learned from counts as much as one you finished. Doing more does not make you worth more.
6. **No surveillance.** The data of your life belongs to you, not to the school.

And one more, which sits on top of the six:

You may refuse the structure itself. If you decline a whole quest, you are fully honored. You are not quietly marked down as a failure or an opt-out. Your no is real.

How we work: the week

The learner’s day runs the morning. Across the week, some days are guide days and some are your own.

- **Guide days (Tuesday and Thursday).** The guide runs the studio with you. The day eases in with a soft, self-directed start, then a body-first settle and a real “how are you, really?” circle, then the work of the day, a shared meal, hands-on and collaborative work, and a light close. (The guide is with the younger children at Vibrant Life Tots on Mondays and Wednesdays, which is why the guide days land on Tuesday and Thursday.)
- **Your-own days (Monday and Wednesday).** You run your own morning: your reading, your core academics, your personal project, and the season’s writing. The guide is on-site and reachable but not directing. That absence is part of the lesson. A young person learns they can hold their own hours. There is a warm check-in around midday.
- **The fallow day (Friday).** Protected. Never earned, never filled, never converted back into work. It is for rest, play, friendship, and making things for no reason. This is not a reward for

finishing. It is practice for a whole life. And it is binding: it does not get eaten to cover a busy week.

The Log, captured however you hold it

You keep the Captain's Log in whatever form is true to you. Written in a notebook. Spoken aloud and recorded. Drawn. Dictated. Typed. Told to a scribe who writes it down for you. No form is the lesser Log. The point is that you are keeping your own record, not that it looks a certain way.

The Vineyard, again

Because it matters: the Vineyard is the thing you love that is never made useful. It runs quietly under the whole year and grows across all three. No one grades it, harvests it, or asks you what it was for. It is offered with a floor - if you have no room for it right now, that is honored too.

How "no" works here

You may decline anything, and you name why. This is called **decline-with-reasoning**, and it is described honestly so you can trust it.

Here is exactly how it works. You can say no to any quest, any prompt, any interview, any share. When you decline, you say the reason - not to earn permission, but because naming the reason is itself part of thinking clearly. The guide may ask you an honest, curious question about it, the way a friend might. But the guide **has a voice, never a veto**. The guide cannot overrule your reason. After the question, your reasoned no stands. The question is a mirror, not a test you can fail.

There is one place where even the curious question is set aside: anything to do with official papers and government forms. There, an honest reason for declining might reveal something private about your legal situation that a guide has no business knowing. So on that one surface, your no needs no reason at all.

The settle

Every guide day opens with a short, body-first way in, and there is a matching way down when something gets heavy. This is fixed, and it is yours to keep for life.

- **The way in (the Settle)**. Three slow breaths with the out-breath longer than the in-breath (roughly four counts in, six counts out), feet flat, one hand where you feel your breath. The

guide paces it out loud, the same way every time. The out-breath is what tells your body it is safe to settle. No app, no playlist, no special frequency. Just a human voice, used the same way on purpose - which means you can say the same words to yourself, anywhere, for the rest of your life.

- **The way down (the discharge).** After hard work stirs the body up, you stand, shake it out, take a short walk, move the activation *through* the body before sitting back down. You cannot metabolize a stress spike sitting still. This is thirty seconds to a few minutes, and it comes before the shared meal, because an activated body cannot receive a meal as belonging.
- **The way out (the exit ramp).** There is a named place you can step out to, set up in the first week. You do not have to ask. And there is a designed way back in during a soft part of the day, with no scene, no acknowledgment demanded. Stepping out and coming back costs you nothing. This is the room holding a door open for you, never the room watching you for a fall.

The closing minute

At the close of an opening - a dream named, a memory touched, a hard thing looked at - you take a quiet minute and cross back through three fixed questions. They are always the same, in the same order:

1. **What did I meet?**
2. **What do I carry back?**
3. **What's different in me now - even a little?**

That is the whole practice. It is spoken or held in your head, never written down for the studio, never read by anyone. It is yours. And **"I don't know yet" is a real answer** to any of them - it closes the practice just as honestly as a clear answer does. "Nothing's different, and I'm steadier for having looked" is also a true and complete answer, because steadier is a change.

The reason this exists: the year opens a lot of doors inside you. This is how you learn to close them yourself, so that when you are grown and something cracks you open, you already know the way home. The measure of it working is not a good answer. It is that you still use it years from now.

The one adult outside the room

There is one adult, outside the studio, you can always talk to. The guide will tell you clearly, on the first day, what stays private here and the one thing that cannot: if you are in danger, or someone is hurting you, the guide's job is to help you get real help, and the guide will. That is not breaking trust. That is what care actually looks like. You will always know who that outside help is and how to reach them, before you ever need them.

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

The shape of the year, and naming the destination on day one

Origin runs from mid-August to early April, then opens into a flex tail called Open Waters that runs into late spring. Seven sessions: four short ones (three weeks each) and three long ones (about six weeks each). The three long sessions span the winter breaks, which is a real teaching and staffing fact you plan around, not around.

On day one, name the destination out loud. Say it plainly in the first week:

SAY

"In about thirty weeks you'll stand and say *this is me* - we call it the Unveiling. Everything between now and then is getting ready to mean it."

The mountain should be visible from the trailhead. A learner walks a long arc better when they can see where it is going.

The safety floor

You are running an examined-life year with teenagers, so the floor under it has to be real, seeded early, and grown as the year deepens. Four pieces:

The settle, the way-down, and the exit ramp. Described in full in Part 1 (the learner reads the same words you do). Teach them in the first week, with the framing that they are the learner's for life. Keep them fixed - same cadence, same anchor, same spoken cue, every guide day. The sameness is the medicine; a settle improvised freshly each day never becomes the reflex a body can drop into without thinking. Anchor the way-down especially at Session 5, where writing a whole life will activate bodies.

The closing minute. Also in Part 1. Teach it light and concrete in Origin. Model it out loud a few times, genuinely, then get out of the way and let it become the learner's private reflex. Name the close; never demand the content. "Take your closing minute" is the whole prompt.

When to reach for outside help (the referral pathway). You are a life-coach and mentor, not a licensed clinician. Sessions surface identity, memory, grief, and hard days by design, so clinical material will come up. Your job is not to treat it. It is to recognize it, hold the moment safely, and route it to real help fast.

Route now, do not "work it in a session," if you see or hear: any mention of suicide, self-harm, or not wanting to be here; disclosure of abuse, neglect, or someone hurting them; acute crisis (panic, dissociation, a flashback, distress you cannot reach); disordered-eating signals; a substance crisis; threats to others; or signs of a condition beyond ordinary distress that is persistent and impairing. **When in doubt, route.** Certainty is a clinician's job, not yours.

In the moment: stay with the learner and never leave them alone in crisis; move to the designated quiet space (named and prepared before the year opens, a real room or corner, not a hallway); be present, calm, and listening; do not fix, probe for details, or counsel; and do not promise secrecy you cannot keep. Name your own honest limit - a solo guide has finite capacity to hold a breakdown and the whole room at once, and that limit is real, not a failing. It is exactly why the whole-absence bench of trusted adults exists.

Two duties you cannot coach around, in Idaho: (a) imminent danger to self or others - call 988 (call, text, or chat, 24/7, free); if life-threatening, call 911. (b) Mandatory reporting - in Idaho everyone is a mandatory reporter, including you. Suspected abuse, neglect, or abandonment of a child must be reported, ideally within 24 hours, and you do not need proof. Statewide 855-552-5437; Treasure Valley 208-334-5437; or 2-1-1, or local law enforcement. This duty overrides the Log's privacy, which is exactly why you name the confidentiality limit on day one. If the parent or guardian is the source of harm, that is a report, not a parent call.

Build the referral roster real before opening - names and current numbers, not categories. The one line that must never stay blank is a named, warm-referral therapist: one or two local licensed clinicians the studio can send a learner to, arranged before the year opens. "Route to real help" is only real if there is a real person to route to.

Keep confidences safe. Almost everything a learner writes and says here is theirs. Say so, up front, on day one, woven into the Two-Way Deal:

SAY

“Almost everything you write and say here is yours and private - your Captain’s Log, no one reads it to judge you. The one thing I can’t keep private is if you’re in danger, or someone is hurting you. Then my job is to help you get real help, and I will. That’s not breaking trust - it’s what care actually looks like.”

A confidentiality limit named up front is a promise kept. Named in the moment, it feels like betrayal. Say it before it is ever needed.

Holding a “no” (the Curious No)

Decline-with-reasoning lives or dies in the single moment a learner actually says no. If that moment collapses into invisible opt-out - silence, the activity just continues around them - the learner is protected by being erased from the room. So hold a no in three beats, and you can run them under load:

1. **Receive the no, whole.** “Okay. You’re not doing this one.” Honor it *before* any curiosity, so your curiosity never lands as a lever.
2. **Offer the door once, and don’t push it.** “If you ever want to tell me what’s behind that, I’d genuinely like to know - no rush, nothing owed.”
3. **Keep them inside the encounter.** “Come sit with me - you don’t have to do the thing.” Removing the task is not the same as removing the person.

Your Socratic question, when you offer it, stays a mirror and never fear-leverage. Ask “when do you think you’ll first run into this for real?” - never “what happens the first time you need this and no one is beside you?” The first opens a door with curiosity; the second forecasts them alone and unequipped, which lands on an anxious learner as “you’ll be sorry.” And whether a fear is “the right kind of scared” is the learner’s to name about themselves, never yours to assign. The instant you re-code a reasoned no as “avoidance” so you can override it, you have smuggled the veto back in as a diagnosis. You have a voice. You never have a veto.

Watch-fors, and protect yourself

You are the floor everyone else stands on. That is not a self-care footnote; it is safety instrumentation. Co-regulation is a physiological output - you spend your own steadiness to

settle a flooded learner, all day. A depleted guide cannot run the watch-and-pivot the whole floor depends on. So:

- **Run your own settle, your own way-down at day's end, and your own closing minute.** Your regulation is part of the design, not an extra.
- **Your fallow day is fallow too.** Protected, not on-call. Do not eat it to cover a hard week.
- **Debrief what you witness, more often than monthly.** Holding teenagers' worst days and self-portraits is a real load. After any safety event, debrief with a peer or supervisor and do not carry it alone. Document incidents factually and minimally (what happened, what you did, who you contacted), never the learner's private content.
- **A pre-committed pause trigger.** If the deep work has been set aside two guide days in a row (from exhaustion or from a hard week), pause to a lighter mode and re-plan rather than push through. Commit to this now, while rested. A depleted person does not pause on instinct; that is exactly when the instinct fails.
- **Permission, in writing.** A deep block you set aside, or a good-enough December day, is the design working, not you failing. This is the Origin year, not a mastery year. The permission the learners get, you take too.

Two general watch-fors across the year: guard against any framing that turns a learner's life into a gap-map ("the quiet region is an invitation, not a deficit"), and remember that feelings are your private hope for a learner, never the session's aim. You cannot schedule "being seen" for a Thursday. Word every joy-flavor as possibility - some feel it, some feel nothing yet, both are true - never as the outcome you are delivering.

Part 3 - The sessions

Each session below has the same seven parts: what it's for, a short intro the learner reads, the flow day by day, things to say, the settle plus the closing minute, watch-fors, and what you'll need. The day-shapes are the same all year (guide days Tuesday and Thursday; your-own days Monday and Wednesday with a midday check-in; Friday fallow), so the flow sections describe what changes, not the fixed grid.

1

The Map of Me

THREE WEEKS

What it's for: to dream with no ceiling and start naming what you actually want.

For the learner: This is where you find out your life is bigger than you have let yourself imagine, and that you can start naming it out loud. You are going to write a hundred dreams. Not the realistic ones - all of them. Then we look at what they say about you. This is the “first creation”: you dream a thing before you build it, and everything the next years build, you dream here first.

The flow:

- **Day 1 (orientation, a special late start).** Belonging first. A shared meal and a walk-in, then the opening circle with the first “how are you, really?” and a name round (pass is always allowed). Then the map of the year. Then the Two-Way Deal: the six refusals offered as a promise, then the tribe co-writes its own agreements (contributions can be written on a card, not only spoken). Then: what Origin is, name your Captain’s Log, name the Vineyard-thing alongside it, and a two-minute first Log entry. Then a tribe-building circle. Then the first quest and a glad close. Send them home with the 100 Dreams assignment.
- **Week 1 (open).** They arrive on the first guide day *with* their dreams. Run the Dream Session (below). The first solo day is narrated so the shape is visible. The second guide day goes deeper: what do your 100 dreams say about what you actually want?
- **Week 2 (deepen).** Sort the dreams by time horizon (within 12 months / one to five years / five-plus years) and notice what the shape reveals. Then map them across the five regions of the Compass the learner already navigates - Self, Others, Making, World, Voice - using warm prompts so no part of life gets missed. The credit and path-map conversations begin this week, warmly, in walk-ins and check-ins - never as a day-two audit.
- **Week 3 (apply, then harvest).** The courage pass: “which of these scares you a little?” Then each learner picks three within-12-months dreams as the season’s orienting goals. Close the session and bridge to The Lineage.

Things to say:

SAY

"Your first quest, before Tuesday: write 100 dreams. No filter, no ceiling, nothing has to be realistic, don't edit a single one. You'll hit a wall around 40 where the easy ones run out - that's exactly where the real ones start, so keep going. Bring your list Tuesday and we'll dig into them together. A hundred is the target, not a gate - bring what you've got."

SAY

"The Compass is how you read your sky; the Log is how you steer - same voyage. You'll navigate by the chart you're building right now."

SAY

"If you hear a dream you want, reach for your pen and add it to your own list. Borrowed dreams count."

SAY

"A thin region isn't a lack - it's a door you haven't walked through yet. What would a fuller one even look like?"

SAY

"Any of these can change, or be dropped, or outgrown at any point, with no failure attached. The dream you no longer want is data about who you're becoming, not a target you missed."

Inside the Dream Session: Debrief the wall first ("who hit the wall at 40? what came up after?") so the wall is a shared story, not a private failure. Go around the circle; each shares one dream aloud, starting with a within-12-months one. Watch the lists grow live as dreams prove contagious. As they share, you begin to hold each learner's dreams with them - "how could we help you live that one?" - which is what makes you a coach and not a teacher. Keep a non-verbal door open (a shared "tribe dreams" wall for the shy) and a warm catch-up for anyone who stalled, so no one who came with 20 leaves ashamed.

The settle and the closing minute: Open every guide day with the settle. Teach the closing minute at its youngest register this session, and use it at each day's close, worded the same way: "What did you meet in your dreams today? What do you carry? What's different in you now, even a little?" Spoken, never written for the studio.

Watch-fors: Do not let the region map read as a deficit ledger - the quiet regions are invitations, not gaps. Keep the credit-map conversation out of day one entirely; belonging roots first. The permission to dream is genuine, so protect it from any quiet “be realistic.”

What you’ll need: The take-home 100 Dreams card (the rule, the wall at 40, a spark bank of warm words, “borrowed dreams count,” “what did you want when you were eight?”). Blank Captain’s Logs in several forms. The five-region prompt map. A “tribe dreams” wall surface. (Note: verify with a real learner which prompt-words get skipped - a skipped door is a dead label. Verify Matthew Kelly’s original list before quoting it as his.)

2

The Lineage

THREE WEEKS

What it's for: to gather the stories of where you come from, and to see that an ordinary life carries enormous meaning.

For the learner: You come from somewhere and someone. This session you learn how to gather a story - how to interview someone you love and listen for the story under the facts - and you bring what you find to a family-story potluck. "Where you come from" is answered whatever your roots are: interrupted, mixed, adopted, chosen, unknown, or forward-facing. Interrupted lineage is still lineage. However you arrive, you belong at this table.

The flow:

- **Week 4 (open, then deepen).** (Labor Day is off.) Open the season: family is who made you. Name the safety net and the empty-state paths *first*, warmly, so everyone knows they belong before anything is asked. The family tree as stories, not a chart. Preview the mortality listening model (an interview between a man and his mother near the end of her life) - name that it touches death and loss, and give a real place to step out to. Then the craft: how to interview someone you love, how to listen for the story under the facts ("what was that time like for you?" not "when were you born?"). Practice in pairs in the room first.
- **Week 5 (deepen).** They bring back what they gathered. Voluntary share of one surprising thing. Reflect the meaning under the facts - a recipe as a story, an ordinary day as a whole world. Begin shaping a story worth telling, lightly. Hold the empty-state paths openly, equal and not lesser.
- **Week 6 (apply, then harvest).** Prepare the short telling that goes with each dish (or the chosen empty-state offering). Set the potluck logistics together. Then the harvest: the family-story potluck itself. Bridge to The Power of Choice.

Things to say:

SAY

"Family is who made you - biological, chosen, or found. A grandparent, a mentor, a coach, a sibling, a neighbor. Whoever left a mark."

SAY

“Your lineage is also who you choose, who you’re building, who you’re becoming. You can be the first of a line. That’s a full front door, not a side exit.”

SAY

“A recipe you wish you had, recreated from memory, is as real an offering as one that’s been handed down for generations.”

SAY

“You choose how much of your story travels to the table - all of it, a little, or none. You’re never the exhibit.”

SAY

“This episode touches death and loss. Here’s where you can step out to, and you don’t owe anyone a reason.”

The settle and the closing minute: Carry the settle and the graduated floor - grief opens for some this session, so use the mid-work discharge and an active close-return on the deep days. Close with the three prompts. Important: do **not** de-role real grief. This is a “that was me, and I carry it, and I’m still here” close, never a “that wasn’t me” one. If an opening runs deeper than a close can hold, hand off warmly to the referral pathway.

Watch-fors: The mortality preview is the sharpest safety point - preview it, name the content, give a real exit, honor opt-out with no explanation. The family interview can surface rupture (estrangement, loss, unknown parents); keep the empty-state paths visible, not buried. Name specific peoples (Eritrean, Nepali, Basque, Diné), never a regional lump. At the potluck, protect the material-poverty path: the studio-provided base dish can quietly *be* a learner’s contribution, pre-arranged so a learner who brings nothing is indistinguishable from one who brought a dish. Presence, not provision. A learner from a marginalized or painful lineage sets their own terms and is never turned into a lesson for the room.

What you’ll need: The previewed mortality listening model with a real exit space. Interview-skill practice prompts. The empty-state offering options, named as equal from day one. Potluck logistics with the inclusion floor (base meal provided, no cover charge, allergen and cultural and religious safe, presence not consumption).

3

The Power of Choice

THREE WEEKS

What it's for: to make choosing a muscle you can feel in your body.

For the learner: You cannot always choose what happens to you. But the space between what happens and what you do next - that space is where your whole freedom lives. This session, you play real choice games until choosing on purpose starts to feel like something you can do deliberately, and you notice the choices you have been making by not choosing. Responsibility, freedom, and choice are one knot, not three topics. And decline-with-reasoning - the way “no” works here - is this exact power, practiced on us: your reasoned no stands.

The flow:

- **Week 7 (open).** Open every guide day this session with a daily choice game (a small, playful, real decision with real consequences). Then the knot: responsibility, freedom, and choice as one thing. Name the honest frame up front (see watch-fors). Then, at a safe distance first - in a story, a film, a moment in history - “where did one choice change everything?” Then, only for those who wish, in their own life.
- **Week 8 (deepen).** Choice games to open. Then, kept light and personal: a choice opens some doors and quietly closes others; there is no free move. Then the turn toward agency - defaults and drift, the choices you make by not choosing. Notice your own patterns without judgment.
- **Week 9 (apply, then harvest).** Each learner names a real choice actually in front of them and practices choosing it deliberately - weighing it, owning it, feeling agency in the body. Then the harvest: name, if you wish, a choice you now own, and the shift from “things happen to me” to “I choose.” Bridge to Running My Own Ship.

Things to say:

SAY

“You can’t always choose what happens. You can always choose your response. That’s the whole game, and it’s enough.”

SAY

"Some of your defaults were handed to you. Noticing one isn't blaming yourself for it - it's just turning the light on."

SAY

"Not 'what should I do?' handed to me. 'Here's how I'm deciding.' That's yours."

The choice games (a starter bank, rotate them): The Fork (pose one small real choice, they choose, then trace what it opened and closed). Would You Rather with real tradeoffs (each option genuinely costs something; argue the gray ones). Yes/No improv (a scene where players may only say "yes-and" or "no"; feel how each shapes what's possible). The Default Game (name a thing you do without deciding; try deciding it on purpose for a day). One Small Path (a choose-your-path story where a tiny early choice cascades - a light taste, not deep consequence work).

The settle and the closing minute: Settle to open. Close with the three prompts. The joy-flavor here is play - agency genuinely feels good in the body - so let the games be fun.

Watch-fors: This is the load-bearing safety point: a session about agency can wound if it implies *everything* is a choice. It is not. Some things happen to a person; some people have had choice taken from them. Never "you chose your circumstances," never "you chose your harm." Always distinguish choices you made from things that happened to you. Keep consequence-thinking light - deep second- and third-order work belongs to a later year; here it stays personal and immediate. Decide observance of Indigenous Peoples' Day given the studio's values.

What you'll need: The choice-game bank. Safe-distance stories or clips for "where did a choice change everything?" Opt-out held open all session; the referral pathway ready.

4

Running My Own Ship

THREE WEEKS

What it's for: to build a routine that actually fits you - the thing that makes freedom possible instead of just noise.

For the learner: Freedom you can't hold is just noise. A routine that fits you is how you actually run your own ship. This is Session 3's power of choice, lived as a rhythm - one that fits *you*, not one imposed on you. Routine is not the opposite of freedom. It is what makes freedom possible. This session you build a routine that survives a bad day, you practice real communication, and you look back at who you are becoming.

The flow:

- **Week 10 (open, then deepen).** The reframe: routine makes freedom possible. Begin designing your own routine (not a template imposed on you). Then time management as craft - time-blocking, energy management (when are *you* sharp?), and the Weekly Plan as the real tool. Design a routine that survives a bad day, not just a good one.
- **Week 11 (deepen, then apply).** Communication foundations - real listening, "I" statements, asking a question worth answering (this feeds the interviewing through-skill and, later, mentor outreach). Then a real communication: draft and send a genuine email to an adult, prepare a needed conversation, or present a plan to the room. Refine your routine from two weeks of running it - what bent, what held.
- **Week 12 (apply, then harvest).** The midpoint look-back on Sessions 1 through 3 - who are you becoming? - and the first credit-pacing check. Then the harvest: name the routine that now fits you, and share (voluntary) one thing the look-back showed you. Bridge to The Full Draft.

Things to say:

SAY

"Routine isn't the opposite of freedom. It's what makes freedom possible. We're building one that fits *you*, not one that's imposed on you."

SAY

“What have these first weeks shown you about yourself? Who are you becoming?”

SAY

“What pace is real for you right now, and does the plan match it? And - is finishing core this year still yours?”

SAY

“A routine that fits you protects the fallow. The un-filled cup is part of the rhythm, not a gap to optimize away.”

The settle and the closing minute: Settle to open; three prompts to close. The joy-flavor is quiet - a clear desk, real momentum, the satisfaction of a rhythm that fits.

Watch-fors: This is the natural readiness moment - assess each learner’s self-management per learner, never by date. Some move toward more autonomy; some keep the full scaffold, and that never reads as remedial. The midpoint look-back is growth-framed, not a shortfall audit - “who you’re becoming,” not “what you didn’t finish.” Guard hard against it becoming a private ledger of falling short. The credit check is a pacing conversation, witnessed, never graded; a learner who needs a multi-year path names it now, adjusting the plan to the learner. Keep communication practice real (a genuine email, a genuine conversation), not role-play only. Decide observance of Election Day (a guide day falls on it); it can be framed as a civics moment.

What you’ll need: The Weekly Plan tool. A real email or conversation for each learner to actually do. The Credit/Path Map for the pacing check. The long haul is next, so a routine that holds is exactly what a learner needs to carry the Full Draft through the winter breaks.

Session 5 - The Full Draft (six weeks, across two breaks)

What it’s for: to claim your whole life on the page - all of it - before you choose what to keep.

For the learner: You cannot shape a story you have not yet dared to tell in full. So first you write all of it - messy, complete, unedited, nothing too small. This is your whole life on the page. Some people feel real relief and catharsis in claiming it; some feel tired, flat, or unfinished. Both are true. No one is asked to perform the feeling. Being witnessed is a gift here, never something you

owe the room. What you write is private by default - it lives in your Captain's Log, which no one reads to judge you - and you choose what, if anything, you say aloud.

The flow (the five prompts, spread across six weeks):

- **Week 13 (open).** Why the whole life first - the relief of getting it all down. Name the safety floor warmly. Prompt 1 - Turning points ("name a moment after which you were not the same"). A recorded-real-lives listening model.
- **Week 14 (deepen).** Prompt 2 - Sensory doorways (a place, a smell, a song, a meal, a room; memory lives in the body before it lives in words). Memoir excerpts as models.
- **Week 15 (deepen, after the first break).** Re-enter with a re-thread first (where were you, where are you). Then Prompt 3 - The people ("who made you? not just family - anyone who left a mark").
- **Week 16 (the hard prompt).** Prompt 4 - The hard and the best (the worst day, the best day, what each taught). This is the sharpest care point - see watch-fors. Follow it with a lighter, held day: coming-of-age songs as mirrors ("which line is about you?"), then back to their own words.
- **Week 17 (apply, into the long break).** Prompt 5 - A slice of life ("write one ordinary day at age ___, start to finish" - a whole world in an ordinary day). Write a re-entry note to your future self so the throughline survives the two-week gap. Consolidate; December runs lighter by design.
- **Week 18 (harvest, after the winter break).** The big re-thread (two weeks away). Push the draft toward whole. Then the harvest: the full draft complete, being witnessed, sharing only what you choose. Bridge to Chapter One.

Things to say:

SAY

"Write all of it - messy, complete, nothing too small. You can't shape a story you haven't yet dared to tell in full. The relief comes from getting it down, not from making it good."

SAY

"You choose what goes on the page and what stays private. A hard thing can be named without being detailed - 'what it taught me' is enough. No one has to relive anything to belong here."

SAY

“A gentler prompt is always available. You can swap any prompt for a softer one, anytime, no reason owed.”

SAY

“You went somewhere real in that memory. What did you meet? What do you carry back? And what’s different in you now that you’ve looked at it - even a little?”

The settle and the closing minute: This is the anchor session for both. On every writing day: the settle to open; mid-work discharge points between hard passages (a thirty-second orient - feet on the floor, look around the room, one breath); an active close-return that names the hard thing is over and lands back in *now*; and a standing exit ramp used without asking. A body that stays inside a worst-day memory for an unbroken hour floods. The closing minute lands hardest here and rides *into* the private Log. This is a “that was me, and I carry it, and I’m still here” close - never de-role real grief. When a close meets something bigger than a close can hold, hand off warmly to the referral pathway. Open no faster than you teach a person to close; this session is where that rule is most literally true.

Watch-fors: This is the heaviest session, and it has a **binding gate**: do not run it with a real learner until both are true - (1) the referral pathway is actually built (a real quiet space, a real named person the crying learner goes to, the honest limit named, plus the clinical hand-off), and (2) the consented safety walk with the real reviewers is done. A trauma-informed floor with an unbuilt trap door is not yet trauma-informed. Coach, not therapist: you hold the container and witness; you do not treat. Re-entry after both breaks is non-negotiable - the two-week winter gap is the highest risk to a learner’s throughline. December runs lighter by design (short dark days, the guide’s own hardest season); postpone depth freely and protect your own fallow. Being witnessed is a gift, never a demand. Decide observance of Veterans Day.

What you’ll need: The five scaffolding prompts. The listening models (recorded real lives, memoir excerpts, the previewed mortality model, coming-of-age songs). Gentler swap-prompts on hand. The built referral pathway and the designated quiet space. The re-entry note format for the winter break.

6

Chapter One

SIX WEEKS

What it's for: to become the author of your own story, and to learn that shaping it small is not making your life small - it is declaring there are chapters to come.

For the learner: A chapter is not a smaller version of your life. It is a shaped thing with a throughline, and you learn to find it. To you, right now, this *is* your whole life - so we don't argue with that, we flip it. Calling it "Chapter One" is an act of hope: it declares there are chapters coming. It doesn't make your life small. It makes your future big. And here is the discipline that keeps this from feeling like loss: we never cut to hide. We cut to focus. Everything you leave out of Chapter One is kept, in the full draft, in your Log. It is still true. It just isn't load-bearing for *this* chapter's shape.

The flow (the shrink mechanic, across six weeks):

- **Week 19 (open).** Become the author; a chapter is a shaped thing with a throughline; introduce the "Chapter One = hope" reframe. Re-read the full draft.
- **Week 20 (the truth-discipline).** (MLK Day is off.) Cut to focus, never to hide; everything cut is kept in the Log, still true. Practice the discipline on a shared example at a safe distance before turning it on their own life.
- **Week 21 (deepen: the throughline).** Shrink step 1: find the throughline ("what is this chapter *about?*" - one sentence). You hold the question; the learner finds the line. A true throughline feels like relief, not a cage.
- **Week 22 (deepen: the load-bearing moments).** Shrink step 2: choose the three to five load-bearing moments that set up who you are becoming. *Keep, because* - never *cut, because*. Everything else moves, honored, into the Log; nothing is lost.
- **Week 23 (apply: write it).** Shrink step 3: write Chapter One - tight, shaped, true. Revision as care; read a passage aloud if you want to.
- **Week 24 (harvest: the second distillation).** Shrink steps 4 and 5: distill the same life into a second shape, the one-page story-of-self and resume. Same material, two forms - a story (meaning) and a page (practical), for two different rooms. Assemble the portfolio. Bridge to the Unveiling.

Things to say:

SAY

“Calling this ‘Chapter One’ isn’t shrinking your life. It’s declaring there are chapters coming. It doesn’t make your life small - it makes your future big.”

SAY

“We never cut to hide. We cut to focus. What you leave out isn’t erased - it’s kept in your Log, still true. It just isn’t load-bearing for this chapter.”

SAY

“Keep this, because . *Not cut this, because* . Choose your keepers by what they set up in who you’re becoming.”

SAY

“The resume is a sovereignty tool - one true page inside your portfolio, yours for the rooms you choose to enter. It’s not the season’s reduction of you to a page.”

The settle and the closing minute: Settle to open; the three prompts to close - the shaping *is* a re-crossing of the whole draft. Memory is still in play here (it draws on the Session 5 draft), so keep opt-out and the coach-not-therapist boundary live.

Watch-fors: Offer the hero’s-journey arc as *one* map, not the frame. The learner whose life is a garden, a spiral, or a set of rooms authors their own shape with equal honor. The learner is the author of their story, never a character in ours. The truth-discipline is the safety - cutting one’s own life can feel like erasure, and the kept-in-the-Log reframe is what makes it authorship. Hold the “Chapter One = hope” reframe whenever the shrinking starts to feel like loss.

What you’ll need: The full drafts from Session 5. A shared safe-distance example to practice the cut-to-focus discipline. The one-page resume format, framed as a sovereignty tool. Portfolio materials.

Session 7 - This Is Me / The Unveiling (six weeks, across spring break)

What it's for: to declare who you are - dreamed in Session 1, drafted in Session 5, shaped in Session 6, now shown to your people.

For the learner: This is the year's harvest. You make a self-portrait - a "This Is Me" piece - in whatever medium is true to you: art, film, music, writing, spoken word, a practice, a set of values. It does not have to be a story. You present it with your portfolio, your resume page, and your Chapter One. Some people feel deeply seen; some feel exposed or flat. Both are honored, and no one performs the feeling. You choose how much you declare and how you are seen. The audience is warm - your people, not a panel. It is a feast, not a judged presentation.

The flow:

- **Week 25 (open).** (Presidents Day is off.) Open with a witness beat *first*: before you turn to your own portrait, witness someone else's story - reflect a peer's Chapter One back to them, or interview an elder - so being-seen becomes reciprocal, not performative. Then: what the Unveiling is, and the year it completes. Begin designing your "This Is Me" piece - what medium is true to you. It need not be a narrative.
- **Weeks 26 to 28 (deepen and apply).** Make the piece (the guide is coach, not critic - the piece is theirs). Share works-in-progress if you want to. Assemble the portfolio into a coherent "who I am now." Refine - the final shaping, nothing forced, everything true. Begin preparing how the piece will be shown.
- **Week 29 (prepare the exhibition).** Prepare the exhibition together; rehearse the telling if you want to; dry-run the Unveiling in the safety of the tribe; hold any nerves warmly. Then spring break.
- **Week 30 (harvest).** Gentle re-entry, final touches, final rehearsal. Then the Unveiling feast: a real celebration with a real audience (families, the tribe), each learner unveiling as much as they choose. Then the year-close (below).

Things to say:

SAY

"Before you turn to your own portrait, witness someone else's. Reflect a friend's Chapter One back to them. Honor another's story before you ask the room to honor yours."

SAY

"Your piece can be anything true to you - an image, a film, a song, a set of values, a practice. It doesn't have to be a story."

SAY

"The tribe is your people. A mentor, a friend's family who adopts you for the night - a chosen witness is honored exactly as much as anyone. You will not fall through this."

SAY

"This is the end of the first year of three. It's allowed to be a little tender. The story continues - next year, we ask what's worth solving."

The year-close: Before Open Waters, two acts. First, a co-authoring close: the learner reviews the year's design *with* you, engines named not hidden - "here's how this year was built, and why; tell me what to change for your next year." A sovereignty act, never a feedback form. Second, the Captain's Log ownership handoff: the Log is theirs; they take it with them, and no copy is kept. The year ends on the learner owning their own record, not the studio archiving it.

The settle and the closing minute: The Unveiling is a public harvest - an opening of the interior onto the social plane - so it needs its private re-crossing afterward: the closing minute at season scale ("what did I meet in showing myself? what do I carry? what's different in me now?"), so the exhibited self comes back into the sovereign interior and the learner is not left "on stage." Then a between-season fallow before the next year opens - never walk a new opening on a body still activated from the feast.

Watch-fors: Being seen is invitational, and being seen can be exposing, especially for the anxious or isolated learner. Offer a real alternative shape, not just "share less": unveil to the tribe only, or in a written or recorded form you present for them, or to one chosen person - each equal, not a lesser path. The family-less learner is the one most exposed by "show your people," so name and hold them: the tribe *is* their people, and a chosen witness is honored equally, never as consolation. Do not let "families come" become a floor a family-less learner falls through on the year's most tender day. Hold the year's close gently; this is a year-close, not a goodbye - the full Launch is a later year. Coach-not-therapist still applies; the piece can surface a lot.

What you'll need: Materials for many mediums. The witness-beat setup (peer reflection or an elder to interview). The feast planned like a real event with the inclusion floor (base provided, presence not consumption, allergen-safe). The co-authoring review structure. The Log handoff.

Part 4 - Closing the year

The Unveiling harvest

The Unveiling is the year's culminating feast, and it deserves real weight and real warmth. It sits outside the daily morning grid - likely an afternoon or evening with families. Plan it like any studio feast, with the full inclusion floor: the base is always provided, no one watches a plate, everyone is allergen-safe, and presence matters more than what anyone brought. Each learner shows their "This Is Me" piece, their portfolio, and their Chapter One, as much as they choose to share. The whole point is being seen by your people in a room that is glad you exist.

Remember the honored empty outcome, here as everywhere: a learner who feels flat, or exposed, or unfinished has not failed the harvest. "I have nothing to declare this season" is a real and honored harvest. The fallow field is part of the crop.

The season-scale re-crossing on the last fallow day

The year opens with a felt beginning and closes with a public harvest - and a public harvest is itself an opening outward. So the season needs its private close, or the learner is left facing out with no way back in. On the year's last fallow day, name the closing minute at the season's scale. It is a naming, not a new ceremony - the fallow day already exists; you are giving it its one true sentence:

SAY

"Before the next season opens, take your closing minute at the whole season's scale. What did you meet this year? What do you carry? What's different in you now - even a little? 'I don't know yet' is a real answer."

Then a real fallow stretch before the next year begins. Never walk a new season's opening on a body still activated from the last one. The learner who is staying needs this between-season close

as much as a graduating learner needs the Launch - it is the arc-scale version of the practice they have run all year, put in their own hand.

After the year: Open Waters

The flex tail runs from mid-April into late spring. It is light structure, not a void: real-world expeditions, personal-project deep dives, high-school-credit close-out for anyone finishing the year's plan, and genuine fallow - rest is a legitimate use of it. Name it to families as intentional: flex plus fallow, not "we'll figure it out." And the bridge into the next year is one sentence: *"You know your story now. Next year: what is worth solving?"*

"We evoke - we never extract." - and that includes the guide, and everyone in the room.